

FRED TALKS

21st April 2026

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Thoughts and Feelings around Claude Design

SAMHENRI.GOLD · 19 APR 2026 · [SOURCE](#)



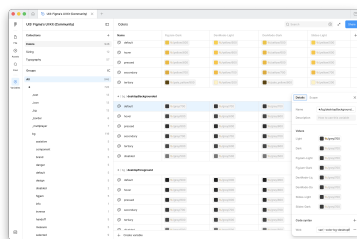
I tried [Claude Design](#) yesterday and I have a theory for how this whole thing shakes out.

As product teams scaled and design needed to justify itself inside engineering orgs, it was pushed toward systematization — and Figma invented its own primitives to make that work: components, styles, variables, props, and so on. Some concepts are borrowed from programming, some aren't, and the whole thing doesn't neatly map onto anything. Guidance evolves, migrations pile up, and if you want to automate any of it you're stuck with a handful of shoddy plugins. The beast is hairy enough that entire design roles now specialize in wrangling the system itself.

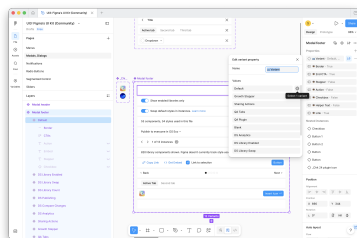
There's always been a tense push-pull between Figma and code over what the source of truth should be. Figma won over Sketch partially by staking its claim there — their tooling would be canonical.

That victory had a hidden cost. By nature of having a locked-down, largely-undocumented format that's painful to work with programmatically, Figma accidentally excluded themselves from the training data that would have made them relevant in the agentic era. LLMs were trained on code, not Figma primitives, so models never learned them. As code becomes easier for designers to write and agents keep improving, the source of truth will naturally migrate back to code. And all the baroque infrastructure Figma had to introduce over the past decade will look nuts by comparison. Why fuss around in a lossy approximation of the thing when you can work directly in the medium where it will actually live? If we want to make pottery, why are we painting watercolors of the pot instead of just throwing the clay?

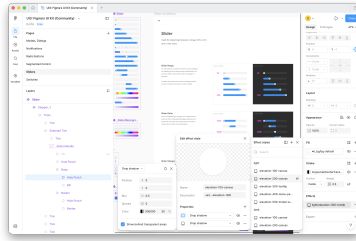
At work, we've spent quite a bit of time back-porting design changes made directly in code back to Figma and it is not fun. I can't share that file, but for a fair comparison, this is Figma's own design system file for their product. I have to assume it was built by the most competent design system team you can find. And yet...



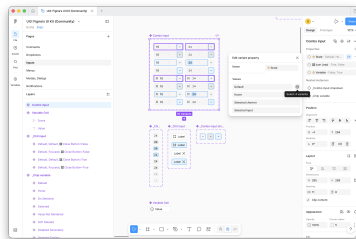
The Figma variables panel showing 946 color variables organized into nested groups like "bg/desktopBackgrounded," with a single selected variable revealing eight mode-specific values: Light, Dark, FigJam-Light, FigJam-Dark, DevMode-Light, DevMode-Dark, Slides-Light, and Slides-Dark.



A modal footer component open to its variant property editor, showing 12 variants with a dropdown full of values like "DS Library Swap," "QA Plugin," "Growth Stepper," and "Sharing Actions." The right panel lists eight props like "Border," "Second CTA," and "Helper Text"



The effect styles panel for a slider component, showing a style named "light/elevation-300-tooltip." Expanding it reveals its entire definition: a 0.5px drop shadow at 30% black. It has its own named style because that's the only way to document what CSS variable it corresponds to.



A combo input component with 16 variants. Its children in the layers panel are named things like "Default, Default, Close Button=False" and "Default, Focused, Close Button=True"

These are Figma's own files. Built by their own team. This is the gold standard.

Imagine debugging a color that looks wrong. You check the component. The component uses a variable. The variable is aliased to another variable. That variable references a mode. The mode is overridden at the instance level. The instance lives inside a nested component with a library swap applied. At this point, you're either considering picking up code or moving to the countryside and becoming a sheep farmer because one more minute of this will make you lose your goddamn mind.

So as the source of truth shifts back to code, Figma is left in an odd spot: holding a largely manual, pre-agentic system that nobody in their right mind would design from scratch today.

I think design tooling forks into two distinct shapes from here — and there's almost a clock resetting between Figma and every other tool competing to answer the same question they answered in 2016: who can help me, a designer, get my ideas out fastest?

Spoiler: it's not Figma Make. Figma Make feels like it primarily benefits people who have already drunk the Kool-Aid — it reads from Figma styles, component libraries, and proprietary props (or, as I like to call them, Prop Props), and it's the only tool in this new landscape still pretending the design file is canonical. It's the tool for people who want to (or have no choice but to) stay inside the system.

Claude Design is the first of those two tools, and takes the opposite bet. There's an Arts and Crafts principle called "[truth to materials](#)" — the idea that a thing should be honest about what it is and how it's made, rather than masquerading as something else. Figma ended up being the opposite of this: a set of extremely rigid schemas with a free-form "just vibes, man" costume over the top. Like a Type-A personality physically incapable of relaxing, forced to perform chill while internally screaming that your frames aren't nested and your tokens are detached and nothing is on the grid. Claude Design, for all its roughness, is at least honest about what it is: HTML and JS all the way down.



A Gustav Stickley lamp table, circa 1902. The joinery is exposed, not hidden. The wood is the wood.

And it has a massive structural advantage: its sibling is Claude Code. Eventually, I can see Claude Design just dumping things directly into Claude Code and vice versa. Claude Design's onboarding already lets you import your repos. The feedback loop between design and implementation — which has been a source of friction since the beginning of time — becomes a single conversation.

The other tool that emerges from this moment will have no expectation of code at all. It'll be a pure exploration environment — somewhere to drop rectangles, stack layer styles, fuss with blend modes and gradients, and go completely nuts, unconstrained by systems or prompting conventions. Maybe it's an iPad app with Pencil support where you just quickly sketch a bunch of rectangles. [37signals could do something really funny right now](#). Or maybe it goes in the opposite direction — something more like Photoshop that goes all-in on high-fidelity compositing and lets our imaginations run wild, now that we're no longer beholden to the ceiling of what you can do with CSS effects. Doesn't it seem *kinda weird* how for 90% of its life, Figma's only layer effect was a drop shadow or a blur?

Figma's Sketch moment is rapidly approaching. And if you said that sentence to a Victorian child, they would probably have a stroke.

Post Script

The following are messages meant only for the teams behind Sketch and Figma. If neither apply to you, you can skedaddle.

To Figma: I can see a world where this post does numbers in the Figma internal Slack. If that's the case and you're reading this from Figma: this wouldn't have happened if you hired me last year when I was interviewing. Your loss, big dawg.

To Sketch: GET YOUR HEADS OUTTA YOUR ASSES AND GIVE EM HELL. ADD PARTICLE EFFECTS. ADD DEBOSSING EFFECTS. MESH TRANSFORMS. FUCK IT, ADD METAL SHADERS. GO NUTS. STOP COASTING OFF OF BEING MAC NATIVE. QUIT DRINKING COCOA AND GET THIRSTY FOR BLOOD.

To mom: Sorry for cursing.

Post-Post Script

[@jonnyburch](#) on Twitter shared a link to [their blog post](#) with similar thoughts, it's quite good if you wanna go deeper.

[Daily article] April 21: Sinestro Corps War

ENGLISH WIKIPEDIA ARTICLE OF THE DAY · 21 APR 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

"Sinestro Corps War" is an American comic book crossover event published by DC Comics in its Green Lantern and Green Lantern Corps titles. Written by Geoff Johns (pictured) and Dave Gibbons, and drawn by Ivan Reis, Patrick Gleason, and Ethan Van Sciver, the 11-part saga was published between June and December 2007 with a main storyline, four supplemental "Tales of the Sinestro Corps" one-shot specials and a Blue Beetle tie-in issue concurrently released. The story centers on the Green Lantern Corps' interstellar war against the Sinestro Corps, led by Sinestro, who seek a universe ruled through fear. The 1986 "Tales of the Green Lantern Corps" story was the thematic basis of the storyline. Critical and fan reception to "Sinestro Corps War"

was positive. Many reviewers ranked it among the top comic books of the year and the storyline's first issue garnered a 2008 Eisner Award nomination. The storyline was a financial success and several issues underwent multiple printings. (Full article...).

Read more: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sinestro_Corps_War

Today's selected anniversaries:

1526:

Ibrahim Khan Lodi, the last ruler of the Lodi dynasty, was defeated and killed by Babur at the First Battle of Panipat, marking the beginning of Mughal rule in India. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/First_Battle_of_Panipat

1836:

Forces of the Republic of Texas led by Sam Houston defeated the Mexican troops of Antonio López de Santa Anna in the Battle of San Jacinto, the decisive and final battle of the Texas Revolution. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Battle_of_San_Jacinto

1925 or 1926:

The al-Baqi Cemetery in Medina, the site of the mausoleum of four of the Twelve Imams of Shia Islam, was demolished by Wahhabis. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Demolition_of_al-Baqi

2021:

The Indonesian Navy submarine Nanggala imploded and sank in the Bali Sea, resulting in the deaths of all 53 people on board. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/KRI_Nanggala_%281980%29

Wiktionary's word of the day:

chaos theory: 1. (mathematics, sciences, uncountable) The study of chaos or disorder in systems, specifically iterative non-linear systems in which arbitrarily small variations in initial conditions become magnified over time, and where within apparent randomness there are underlying patterns; (countable) one of such theories. 2. About Word of the Day 3. Nominate a word 4. Leave feedback https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/chaos_theory

Wikiquote quote of the day:

The human heart has hidden treasures, In secret kept, in silence sealed; The thoughts, the hopes, the dreams, the pleasures, Whose charms were broken if revealed. --Charlotte Brontë https://en.wikiquote.org/wiki/Charlotte_Bront%C3%AB

Types of Board Game

XKCD.COM · 21 APR 2026 · SOURCE



I can't believe Candles of Vienna caved to commercial pressure and added the Goku expansion.

2.1.116

CHANGELOG · 20 APR 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

- `/resume` on large sessions is significantly faster (up to 67% on 40MB+ sessions) and handles sessions with many dead-fork entries more efficiently
- Faster MCP startup when multiple stdio servers are configured; `resources/templates/list` is now deferred to first @-mention
- Smoother fullscreen scrolling in VS Code, Cursor, and Windsurf terminals — `/terminal-setup` now configures the editor's scroll sensitivity
- Thinking spinner now shows progress inline ("still thinking", "thinking more", "almost done thinking"), replacing the separate hint row

- `/config` search now matches option values (e.g. searching "vim" finds the Editor mode setting)
- `/doctor` can now be opened while Claude is responding, without waiting for the current turn to finish
- `/reload-plugins` and background plugin auto-update now auto-install missing plugin dependencies from marketplaces you've already added
- Bash tool now surfaces a hint when `gh` commands hit GitHub's API rate limit, so agents can back off instead of retrying
- The Usage tab in Settings now shows your 5-hour and weekly usage immediately and no longer fails when the usage endpoint is rate-limited
- Agent frontmatter `hooks`: now fire when running as a main-thread agent via `--agent`
- Slash command menu now shows "No commands match" when your filter has zero results, instead of disappearing
- Security: sandbox auto-allow no longer bypasses the dangerous-path safety check for `rm/rmdir` targeting `/`, `$HOME`, or other critical system directories
- Fixed Devanagari and other Indic scripts rendering with broken column alignment in the terminal UI
- Fixed `Ctrl+-` not triggering undo in terminals using the Kitty keyboard protocol (iTerm2, Ghostty, kitty, WezTerm, Windows Terminal)
- Fixed `Cmd+Left/Right` not jumping to line start/end in terminals that use the Kitty keyboard protocol (Warp fullscreen, kitty, Ghostty, WezTerm)
- Fixed `Ctrl+Z` hanging the terminal when Claude Code is launched via a wrapper process (e.g. `npx`, `bun run`)
- Fixed scrollbar duplication in inline mode where resizing the terminal or large output bursts would repeat earlier conversation history
- Fixed modal search dialogs overflowing the screen at short terminal heights, hiding the search box and keyboard hints

- Fixed scattered blank cells and disappearing composer chrome in the VS Code integrated terminal during scrolling
- Fixed an intermittent API 400 error related to cache control TTL ordering that could occur when a parallel request completed during request setup
- Fixed `/branch` rejecting conversations with transcripts larger than 50MB
- Fixed `/resume` silently showing an empty conversation on large session files instead of reporting the load error
- Fixed `/plugin` Installed tab showing the same item twice when it appears under Needs attention or Favorites
- Fixed `/update` and `/tui` not working after entering a worktree mid-session

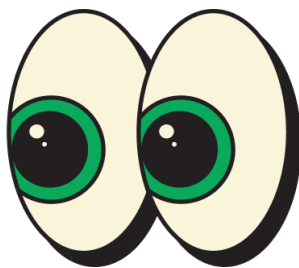
Bytes: Agent-chella 2026

TYLER FROM FIRESHIP · 20 APR 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

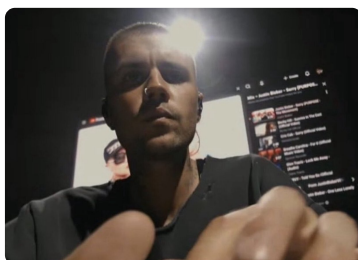


Today's issue: MDN does the most MDN thing ever, OpenCode migrates to Electron, and my codebase is 6'5" btw.

Welcome to [#479](#).



THE MAIN THING



*POV you're an agent that just broke in front of
100,000 people*

Agent-chella 2026

Building agents is a lot like going to Coachella: it sounds fun to do what all the cool kids are doing, but before you know it you're drowning in infinite loops and influencer sweat. At least I hope that's sweat.

The problem is that for an agent to be halfway useful, it needs to be able to access the internet like a real human. And REST APIs don't let it log into sites, fill out forms, or do other tasks that are actually helpful.

Most developers are trying to patch this together with Playwright scripts and hardcoded selectors. But brittle automation and agents are a terrible combination, because one DOM update makes everything break.

Stagehand is an open source SDK that's solving this problem by combining deterministic code with natural language AI.

It does this by giving your agent four primitives for surviving the real web:

- **act()** : plain-English browser actions that [resolve at runtime](#), so instructions like “click the submit button” still work after a site redesign
- **extract()** : grabs structured data from any page using a Zod schema with no selectors required
- **observe()** : surfaces what's actually actionable on a page before your agent commits to anything

- `agent()` : autonomous multi-step execution for when you want to hand off an entire workflow, like booking a flight on the Frontier Airlines site that hasn't been updated since 2004

Bottom Line: Most web agent demos you see are either faked or so convoluted that they're slower than just doing the task yourself. Open source tools like Stagehand are the best hope we have for getting out of the uncanny valley.



OUR FRIENDS (WITH BENEFITS)



*My team's 45 PRs watching my agent open another
PR*

[When AI is opening PRs, you need AI that can test them just as fast.](#)

Agent-assisted development speeds up your engineers, but without a QA process that can keep up, those PRs are sitting around untested and unreleased.

Join QA Wolf CEO Jon Perl for a [live webinar](#) on how QA Wolf uses AI to ship every day without bugs.

You'll see how QA Wolf's AI:

- Finds critical workflows and turns them into deterministic test coverage
- Runs tests in parallel to catch issues before they hit production
- Gets fast signal on PRs before merge

[RSVP here](#) — and see what shipping with confidence looks like.



SPOT THE BUG

Sponsored by [Orkes](#)

They wrote a practical walkthrough on [how to make distributed workflows retry-safe](#), so you can prevent duplicate side effects in your app.

```
class ChatApp {  
  constructor() {  
    this.keywordRegex = /hello|hi|hey/g;  
  }  
}
```

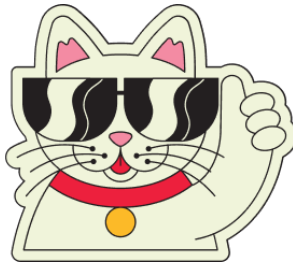
```
}

receiveMessage(message) {
  if (this.keywordRegex.test(message)) {
    this.sendGreeting();
  }
}

sendGreeting() {
  console.log("ChatApp: Hello, how can I assist you?");
}

let chatApp = new ChatApp();

chatApp.receiveMessage("hi, how are you?");
chatApp.receiveMessage("hello, can you help me?");
```



COOL BITS

1. [Vercel got hacked](#) over the weekend when a third-party AI tool used by one of their employees was compromised, allowing the attackers to get access to sensitive customer data. If you haven't been contacted by Vercel, it means you probably weren't affected. Guillermo mentioned that this attack was probably "significantly accelerated by AI," so I guess this kind of thing will just keep happening now.
2. Clerk just introduced [B2B authentication](#) so you can enable your users to quickly set up organizations, invite members, and assign roles in one flow. [sponsored]
3. In a big blow to pirated sports streaming websites everywhere, Google introduced a [new spam policy for "back button hijacking"](#).
4. Ivan Cernja wrote about [what the Encore team learned building a Rust runtime for TypeScript](#), including the non-obvious problems of making Node and Rust work together.
5. Build dynamic forms that work your way. With SurveyJS, you get a [fully customizable JavaScript form builder](#) that integrates seamlessly with any backend—no vendor lock-in, or usage limits. [sponsored]
6. TkDodo wrote about [the benefits of a vertical codebase](#). My codebase is 6'5" btw.
7. [pnpm 11 RC](#) just shipped with a new SQLite-backed store index and supply-chain protection turned on by default. I know you hate opinionated defaults, but this one *probably* makes sense.
8. [OpenCode desktop migrated to Electron](#) because it's "faster and more reliable" than their Tauri build. Rust-maxxers are invited to take a personal day to process the news.
9. The Databased podcast broke down [6 counterintuitive systems design principles that agents don't understand](#) with the founder/CTO of Convex, Jamie Turner. [sponsored]

10. Leo McArdle wrote this deep dive going [under the hood of MDN's new frontend](#). MDN going all in on Web Components is the most MDN thing ever and I love that for them.
 11. [Yuku](#) is a high-performance JS/TS compiler and toolchain written in Zig that's 100% JS spec compliant.
 12. The GitHub team wrote about [the uphill climb of making diff lines performant](#). Please enjoy it during the 47 minutes per day when GitHub isn't down.
-



SPOT THE BUG: SOLUTION

Sponsored by [Orkes](#)

```
chatApp.receiveMessage("hi, how are you?"); // "Chat
chatApp.receiveMessage("hello, can you help me?"); /
```

In JavaScript, RegExp objects with the `g` (global) flag retain state between matches due to the `lastIndex` property, which can lead to unexpected results when reused across different inputs.

The solution is to create a fresh RegExp object for each incoming message, ensuring proper recognition and response to all greetings.

```
class ChatApp {
  receiveMessage(message) {
    let keywordRegex = /hello|hi|hey/g;
    if (keywordRegex.test(message)) {
      this.sendGreeting();
    }
  }

  sendGreeting() {
    console.log("ChatApp: Hello, how can I assist you");
  }
}

let chatApp = new ChatApp();

chatApp.receiveMessage("hi, how are you?"); // "ChatApp: Hello, how can I assist you"
chatApp.receiveMessage("hello, can you help me?"); // "ChatApp: Hello, how can I assist you"
```



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